

ALCARAZ BECAME THE YOUNGEST MAN,
AT 21, TO CAPTURE A GRAND SLAM TITLE
ON HARD, CLAY, AND GRASS COURTS

double faulted twice for love-30 and lost his serve when the opportunistic Alcaraz hit a terrific low volley winner and a forehand approach winner.

Perhaps the angst from Zverev's lingering domestic abuse case, which was settled out of court four days before, or the stress from surviving two five-setters had taken a toll.

Alcaraz also looked nervous when he committed three unforced groundstroke errors and a double fault to give away his serve in the next game.

By returning Sascha's massive first serve from 20 feet behind the baseline — a yard more than Daniil Medvedev's extremely deep position — Alcaraz blunted its power, which he failed to do at the Australian Open in January during his four-set loss. "That was one of the biggest serving exhibitions I've ever seen," said McEnroe. "And I've seen [Pete] Sampras and [Boris] Becker."

Alcaraz used the smart tactic to break serve twice more to grab the first set 6-3. A lunging backhand volley winner and an improvised

swinging forehand volley in the eighth game prompted Carillo to say, "Is there any shot this guy doesn't have?"

Zverev found his groove in the second set to turn the tide. He struck his forehand with more power and less loopy topspin, while Alcaraz lost concentration, energy, and consistency. Two serve breaks gave the 6'6" German the surprisingly decisive second set, 6-2.

To regain his energy, Carlos drank pickle juice during changeovers. He staved off three break points to take the (seemingly) pivotal seventh game for a 5-2 lead in the pivotal third set. But abruptly and unpredictably, Sascha reversed the momentum again.

Alcaraz played a terrible tactical game serving for the set at 5-3, missing a half volley in no-man's-land on the first point and rushing the net with a crosscourt approach to Zverev's strong backhand wing — a double mistake — on break point. At the 5-6 changeover, the Spaniard complained to the umpire, saying

there is no clay and it's playing like a hard court. Gusts blew the top dressing away and took the wind out of his sails. Zverev grabbed the last five games and the third set, 7-5.

Alcaraz quickly reset to reverse the momentum again in the roller coaster match. He reeled off three straight service breaks, the first clinched with a pinpoint forehand passing shot and the second with a cruel drop shot that Zverev didn't run for. The fickle French fans that chanted for Zverev to ignite his third-set comeback now chanted "Carlos! Carlos!" to boost him.

Ahead 4-0, Alcaraz called for a medical timeout. An ATP physio worked on his left leg while a physician gave him a painkiller.

When Alcaraz served for the set at 5-1 and fell behind 15-40, McEnroe said, "It's incredibly unpredictable right now." It didn't turn out that way as Alcaraz won four straight points to take the 6-1 set.

Alcaraz had the momentum now, but both players had reason to be confident. Alcaraz owned a